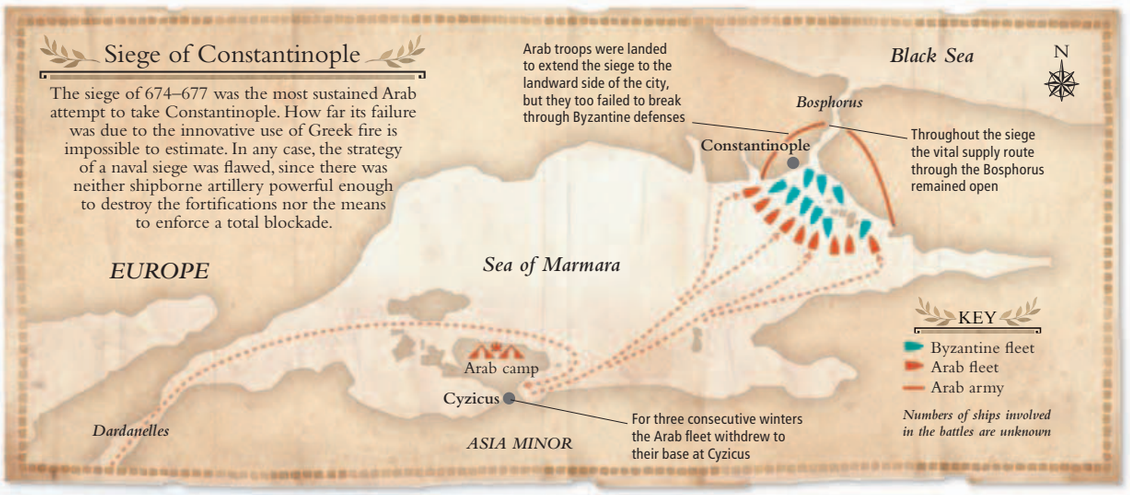
THE SIEGE OF CONSTANTINOPLE

The establishment of the Umayyad Caliphate in Damascus, Syria, in 661 was followed by a reinvigoration of Arab efforts to conquer the Byzantine Empire. Caliph Muawiyah understood the importance of sea power and in 672 sent a fleet through the Dardanelles into the Sea of Marmara, where it established a base at Cyzicus, about 80km (50 miles) from Constantinople. Four years later Muawiyah's son Yazid led a full-scale naval attack on the Byzantine capital.



A FOUR-YEAR CAMPAIGN

The Byzantine ruler, Constantine IV, was a vigorous leader who ensured the city's defenses were in excellent repair. The Arabs used their ships as artillery platforms, sailing up to the city walls and bombarding them with rocks from giant catapults mounted on deck. The Byzantines responded with harassing sorties by small, fast-moving galleys, some of them probably employing the newly invented Greek fire as a shock tactic. The Byzantine fleet also prevented the Arabs sailing into the Bosphorus, which remained a lifeline for grain supplies from across the Black Sea.

The Arab attacks on Constantinople were maintained through the summer of 674 without much effect on the impressive fortifications. In October the Arab fleet withdrew to Cyzicus, where they refitted their ships and rested their crews, ready to renew the fight in the spring. This pattern was repeated stubbornly through to fall 677, before the Arabs finally gave up. In that year they suffered two disasters. They were defeated by a Byzantine fleet at Syllaeum, a site probably in the Sea of Marmara, and a large part of a force returning to Syria was sunk in a storm.



The walls of Constantinople
When the Arabs attacked Constantinople in 674, the city was protected by the Theodosian Walls, built in the 5th century CE. Restored stretches of the land wall still stand, though the original sea wall has long since disappeared.



BYZANTINE–ARAB WARS

SIEGE OF CONSTANTINOPLE

Date	674–677
Location	Sea of Marmara, near Istanbul, Turkey
Result	Byzantine victory

COMBATANTS

BYZANTINE EMPIRE	UMAYYAD CALIPHATE

COMMANDERS

Emperor Constantine IV	Caliph Muawiyah I

FORCES

Ships: unknown	**Ships:** unknown

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** unknown	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** unknown

BYZANTINE–ARAB WARS

CARTHAGE



Date 698
Forces Byzantines: unknown; Arabs: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Carthage, near present-day Tunis

When the port of Carthage was lost in the Arab advance across North Africa, Byzantine Emperor Leontius sent a large fleet under Ioannes the Patrician to retake the city. Caught by surprise, the Arabs were defeated at sea and Carthage returned to Byzantine rule—but not for long. The Arabs mounted a siege by sea and land. The city held out while resupplied by sea, but eventually the Arab fleet broke through the line of ships defending the harbor. Carthage fell but Ioannes escaped with much of the fleet, only to be murdered by his second-in-command, a German called Apsimarus. With the support of his mutinous crews, Apsimarus then sailed to Constantinople and seized the throne as Emperor Tiberios III.

BYZANTINE–ARAB WARS

CALABRIA



Date 964
Forces Byzantines: unknown; Arabs: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Off Calabria, southern Italy

In 827 Arabs and Berbers invaded Byzantine-ruled Sicily from North Africa. The struggle for control of the island lasted for more than a century, during which time Byzantine naval forces based in southern Italy fought a number of battles with an Arab fleet based in Palermo. By 964 Byzantine resistance was at an end and Patriarch Nicetas organized a squadron of ships to evacuate the last Byzantine forces from eastern Sicily. Unfortunately the squadron was intercepted by a superior Arab force off the coast of Calabria. The Arabs reportedly used swimmers to attack the Byzantine ships with incendiary devices, an unconventional tactic that contributed to the total destruction of the patriarch's squadron.